

Payment Methods - Agent Knowledge Base

How to answer questions about accepted payment methods, declines, authorizations, duplicate charges, and payment-data safety.

Prototype disclaimer

Synthetic sample policy for prototyping and RAG evaluation. This document is fictional operational guidance, not a statement of any real company's policy. Adapt, validate, and approve it before production use.

Retrieval metadata

Applies to: customer support agents, ticket triage agents, and automated support agents

Recommended ticket tags: payment_method, card_decline, wallet, pending_authorization, duplicate_charge

Policy status: synthetic / test corpus

Policy summary

Northstar Commerce accepts major credit and debit cards, supported digital wallets, and store credit where displayed at checkout. Available methods can vary by country, device, order value, and fraud controls. Support agents cannot manually add a payment method to an order.

Core rule

A payment method is considered supported only if the checkout page offers it to that customer for that transaction. Do not promise a method that is not displayed at checkout.

Decision rules

Situation	Agent action	Escalate when
Customer asks whether a card or wallet is accepted	Ask the customer to confirm whether it appears at checkout. Explain that availability is transaction-specific.	The checkout shows a method but repeatedly fails after basic troubleshooting.
Payment is declined	Do not retry on the customer's behalf. Suggest checking billing details, available funds, bank controls, or using another displayed method.	Multiple supported methods fail or the account is blocked from checkout.
Customer wants to split payment across two cards	Explain that split tender is not supported unless checkout explicitly provides it. Store credit may be combined only when checkout permits.	A documented enterprise or marketplace exception applies.
Customer sees a pending authorization	Explain that a temporary authorization can appear after an attempt and normally releases automatically if the order was not completed.	The authorization remains beyond 7 calendar days or the bank confirms it settled as a charge.
Customer requests payment-method change after order placement	Payment method cannot be edited on an existing order. If cancellation is still available, customer may cancel and reorder.	Order appears duplicated or charged more than once.

Agent workflow

- Verify order number if an order exists; otherwise treat it as a checkout issue.
- Confirm exact error text without asking for full card number, CVV, or bank credentials.
- Ask whether another payment method shown at checkout works.
- For suspected duplicate charge, compare order IDs, timestamps, and transaction status before escalating.

Data handling boundaries

Agents may ask for card brand, last four digits, billing postal code, and approximate charge amount when needed for lookup. Agents must never request or store full card numbers, CVV/CVC, PINs, bank passwords, one-time passwords, or wallet recovery phrases.

Never request

Full PAN/card number, CVV, PIN, OTP, online banking password, or screenshots containing complete payment credentials.

Suggested ticket fields

issue_type=payment; payment_stage=checkout|authorization|charged;
payment_method=card|wallet|store_credit|other; error_message; order_id_if_any;
duplicate_charge_suspected=yes|no; escalation_reason

Frequently asked questions

Q: Why was my card declined?

A: Northstar Commerce usually receives only a generic decline response. Ask the customer to verify billing details and contact the card issuer if the same card keeps failing. Do not speculate that fraud or insufficient funds caused the decline.

Q: Can I pay with two cards?

A: Not unless checkout explicitly offers split payment. Agents cannot manually divide a charge.

Q: I was charged but received no order confirmation. What should I do?

A: Check for a completed order using the customer account, email, amount, and approximate time. If no completed order exists, treat the charge as an authorization unless it is confirmed as settled. Escalate settled charges with no matching order.

Q: Can you change the card on my order?

A: No. Payment credentials cannot be swapped on an order after placement. If cancellation remains available, the customer can cancel and place a new order.

Q: Why is PayPal/Apple Pay/another wallet missing?

A: Wallet availability can vary by device, browser, country, order contents, and risk controls. Only methods displayed at checkout are currently available.

Q: How long does a failed-payment authorization take to disappear?

A: Most issuers release it within several days. Escalate if it remains beyond 7 calendar days or the issuer says it fully settled.

Agent response principle

State what is known, distinguish it from what is estimated, give the customer the next concrete step, and never promise an outcome outside the rules in this knowledge base.